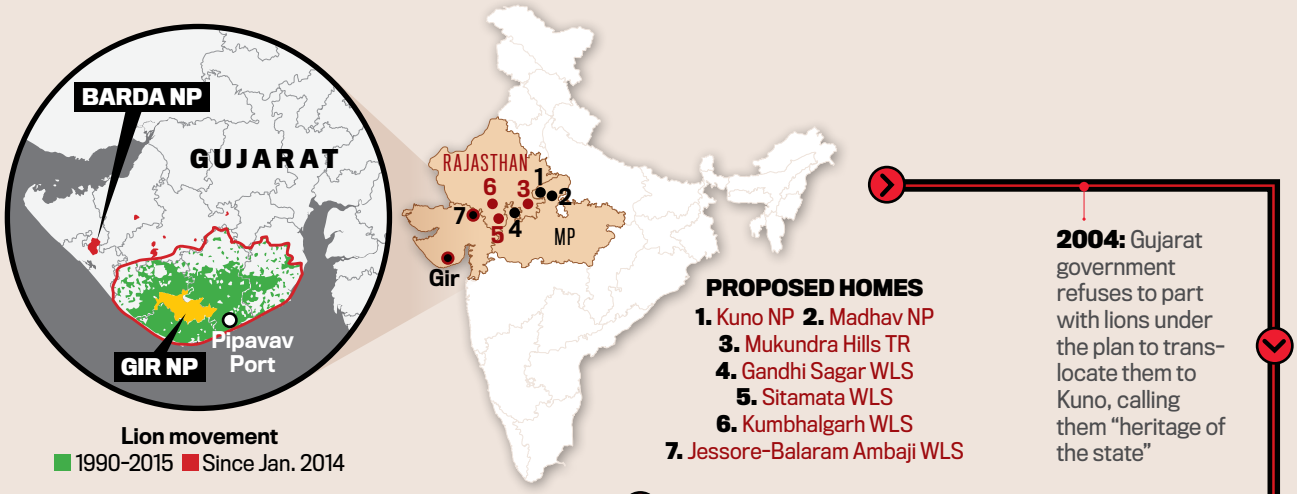


were never examined from a scientific viewpoint either by the state or by the Union ministry of environment, forests and climate change (MoEFCC). Asked about their status, S.P. Yadav, member secretary, National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA), says, "The new report is yet to be released."

Things, therefore, remained where they were, as the MoEFCC and NTCA now cited the introduction of the Namibian cheetahs in Kuno as the reason for not going ahead with the pending transfer of lions there. In a submission made to the SC in March 2023, the Centre, besides painting the proposed introduction of lions as a threat to cheetahs in Kuno, mentioned Gujarat's stellar record of lion conservation as the reason for not going ahead with the transfer. Further, the Supreme Court was informed that the Centre would take a fresh look at the translocation of lions to Kuno within six months. The submission could be an attempt to end the decades-long quest for a second home for *Panthera leo leo*. The MoEFCC also stated: "Although the cheetah and lion are known to co-exist in Africa...competitively subordinate and vulnerable carnivores (cheetahs) should be released prior to dominant species (lions)."

While the non-compliance with the court order has had conservationists upset, the latest move by the MoEFCC has added to their frustrations. "There is a standing order of the SC that has directed that the lions be translocated to Kuno. There is no reason for the state and Union governments to have delayed it for 10 years. All possible options of appeal have been exhausted by the Gujarat government," says Chellam.



"WE ARE CONFIDENT THAT BARDA WILL EMERGE AS A HABITAT FOR LIONS. THREE LIONS HAVE NATURALLY MIGRATED THERE"

–NITYANAND SRIVASTAVA
Chief wildlife warden, Gujarat

Meanwhile, the MP government's stand on the lion translocation project has been curiously muted. While Gujarat has been aggressively opposing the move, the MP government has not been pursuing it. After the Centre's submission at the apex court, there is no clarity if MP would oppose it in court. But 2023 is an election year in MP, and according to the Congress, the transfer of lions at Kuno, with or without the cheetahs, could have created jobs in one of the poorest regions of the state.

With the cheetahs in Kuno, you could say that MP's effort and expense in developing Kuno for a big cat reintroduction have not gone in vain. But the barrage of problems that impelled the WII to advise translocation of lions in the first place have come to a head in Gujarat. According to data released in the Gujarat legislative assembly recently, seven humans have died and 40 injured in lion attacks in two years. Such deaths numbered five in 2022, a rise from two in the previous year. The victims included two children sleeping alongside their parents in a village adjoining agricultural land. Given that 2011-2021 saw around 12 incidents on an average annually and